Tibet deepened. At his inauguration, the prime minister invited Lobsang Sangay, the sikyong (or president) of the Tibet government-in-exile, to attend. A group of Chinese dissidents was allowed to hold a conference in Dharamsala in April 2016. In December 2016, the Dalai Lama was invited to an event at Rashtrapati Bhavan and had a meeting with President Pranab Mukherjee. The Dalai Lama was later given permission to visit Taiwan. In March 2017, he was also allowed to visit Tawang accompanied by Minister of State for Home Affairs Kiren Rijiju, and in July of that year, during the Doklam stand-off, Sangay was allowed to unfurl the Tibetan flag at Pangong Tso. In preparation for the informal summit in Wuhan in April 2018, India dialled back this tougher policy – for instance, discouraging official participation in Tibetan activities in India – but by then Delhi had shown its teeth on Tibet. Those teeth were to show again in Ladakh in 2020 when the Indian military used the Special Frontier Force manned by Tibetan refugees. The death of one of the fighters during the deployment was marked by a highly publicized official funeral attended by a leading functionary of the Bharatiya Janata Party.

Military Relations

After the 1986–87 confrontation at Sumdorong Chu, Delhi and Beijing recognized the need to stabilize military relations. In 1993 and 1996, they signed two major confidence-building agreements. Both agreements were regarded as successes – and indeed, they seemed to promise a period of never-ending peace at the border. Yet by 2008, the Indian military was recording an increasing number of incursions by China (the Chinese side does not publicly report Indian incursions). After Xi Jinping's rise to power in 2012, the two militaries squared off almost annually – at Depsang in 2013, at Chumar in 2014, at Burtse in 2015, at Doklam in 2017, and in a broad swathe in Ladakh in 2020, despite another series of confidence-building measures. We see here too a 'repeat' of the 1950s and early 1960s before the war: India and China negotiating on a border settlement and